Beijing. Indian positions in global negotiations, such as on the Japanese Peace Treaty, brought out its calculations in respect of China.

The 1950s were certainly a period of camaraderie between the two nations and pictures of their leaders together convey that strongly. It was, of course, a relationship that served China, the more diplomatically isolated of the two countries then, much better. On the whole, despite the growing border differences, India was a real believer in this phase of ties. Underneath, however, there were latent tensions that were building as their transition to nation states advanced. These were to eventually feature prominently in a Sino-Soviet polemic that motivated the Chinese leadership in a way that only Communists can comprehend. The phase ended as all these issues came to a head simultaneously.

While there may be a positive recollection that still serves political convenience, it does not erase the beliefs of this period that have struck roots. Chinese nationalism had already generated a comparative history that attributed weaknesses to Indian society. To that was added now the view of democracy as apparently lacking in discipline and fortitude. These caricatures were hardly the basis for an easy equilibrium as the two societies embarked on their individual journeys of development. However, the second set of realities is valuable because they can be evoked whenever there is a mutual desire to find common ground. In fact, the coming together at the BRICS or the Shanghai Cooperation Organization is very reminiscent of this period. For all their issues with each other, India or China have at the back of their mind a feeling that they are also contesting an established Western order. They can conveniently pull out this positive view of their history whenever it suits them.

If there is indeed a history that still counts, it is the modern one. And that, truth be told, is not an easy inheritance. This third set of realities encompasses the difficult aspects of the ties, as the first flush of engagement gave way to hard security and competitive politics. It was inevitable that once they emerged as independent states establishing their borders, India and China would have to come to terms with each other. Even otherwise, it would have been a challenge to arrive at a compromise. But as this problem got entangled with China’s management of Tibet, its